

Chapter 16: Nowhere Left to Pretend

Jenny didn't ask what he meant.

Not immediately.

Because if she did, she would have to acknowledge that something had already changed.

And she wasn't ready for that.

So she did what she always did.

She worked.

She moved.

She avoided.

But avoidance had started failing her lately.

Because Austin was still there.

Still at table seven.

Still watching the room in that quiet, unreadable way.

And still... watching her.

Jenny noticed every time.

Even when she tried not to.

"Order up!" Bao called.

Jenny grabbed the tray.

"Got it."

But her attention split.

Again.

She passed Austin's table.

He looked up.

She didn't stop.

Not this time.

But his voice still reached her.

"Jenny."

She stopped anyway.

Annoyed at herself more than him.

"Yes?"

"You're avoiding again."

Jenny turned slowly.

"I'm working."

"That's not what I said."

She sighed.

"What do you want?"

A pause.

Then—

"Nothing."

That made her frown.

"...Nothing?"

Austin nodded once.

"I just wanted you to stop walking past me like I'm not here."

Jenny blinked.

That shouldn't have mattered.

It did.

She crossed her arms.

"I'm busy."

"I know."

A beat.

Then softer—

"But you still look."

Jenny froze slightly.

Behind them, the restaurant noise continued.

But between them...

It narrowed again.

Jenny forced her voice steady.

"You're imagining things."

"I'm not."

That simple answer again.

Always calm.

Always sure.

It was starting to undo her.

Jenny turned away quickly.

"Finish your food."

She didn't wait for a response.

But she still felt it.

His presence.

Even when she wasn't near him.

Even when she was in the kitchen.

Even when Bao was talking too loudly about nothing.

It followed her.

Like a thought she couldn't finish.

By late afternoon, Madam Chen called her over.

"You've been distracted all day."

"I'm fine."

"You dropped a receipt."

"It was slippery."

"And you stared at table seven for a full minute without moving."

Jenny paused.

"...That's not true."

Madam Chen raised an eyebrow.

Jenny sighed.

"Okay. Maybe I did."

The older woman studied her.

Then said quietly,

"You should be careful."

Jenny frowned.

"About what?"

Madam Chen didn't answer immediately.

Then—

"Men like him don't usually stay."

That hit differently.

Jenny looked toward the dining area.

Austin was still there.

Still.

Present.

Not like someone passing through.

Like someone choosing to remain.

Jenny's voice lowered.

"He said he's not leaving."

Madam Chen gave her a long look.

"And you believe him?"

Jenny didn't answer.

Because she didn't know anymore.

When the restaurant finally quieted, Jenny expected him to leave.

He didn't.

Of course he didn't.

Instead, he stayed.

As usual.

Working.

Reading.

Watching.

Jenny finally walked over.

"You're not going?"

"I said I'm not leaving."

"That was this morning."

"And I still mean it."

Jenny exhaled.

"You're impossible."

"I've been told."

She looked at him properly.

"You can't just... insert yourself into my life like this."

"I didn't insert myself."

"Yes, you did."

Austin shook his head slightly.

"I came to eat."

Jenny gave him a flat look.

"For the first time, sure."

A faint pause.

Then—

"That's not true."

She frowned.

"What?"

"I noticed you before you noticed me."

That stopped her.

Jenny blinked.

"...That doesn't make sense."

"It does."

"How?"

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then said quietly,

"You just weren't looking at me yet."

Silence.

Jenny didn't respond.

Because that was exactly the problem.

She had started looking.

Too often.

Too long.

And now she couldn't stop noticing when he wasn't looking back.

She sat down across from him without thinking.

Immediately regretted it.

Austin noticed.

"You sit more now."

Jenny crossed her arms.

"Don't make it sound like a habit."

"It is becoming one."

She narrowed her eyes.

"I don't like that."

"I didn't say I do either."

That made her pause.

Then she said quietly,

"This is getting out of control."

Austin studied her.

"I think it already is."

Jenny looked away.

Of course she did.

But this time...

He didn't let the silence stretch too long.

"I don't want to leave when I do," he said.

Jenny looked back at him.

Confused.

"You already said you're not leaving."

"I mean eventually."

That word landed heavier than expected.

Eventually.

Jenny's chest tightened slightly.

"Oh."

Austin continued.

"But I also don't want to stay in a way that makes you uncomfortable."

Jenny laughed softly.

"You're already doing both."

A faint exhale from him.

Almost a smile.

"Then I suppose I'm failing at balance."

Jenny hesitated.

Then quietly—

"Yeah."

A pause.

Then Austin said,

"But I still want to stay."

That was the difference.

Not pressure.

Not demand.

Just want.

Jenny stared at him.

And for the first time...

She didn't immediately tell herself to stop feeling something.

She just felt it.

And that was worse.

Because now she couldn't pretend she didn't know.